

Tours Programme (FTP) slots India in for seven Tests against Bangladesh, Zimbabwe and New Zealand, it may end up with only five as Zimbabwe is yet to be formally confirmed.

That could lead to crockery being smashed in the Dravid and Laxman households. It has taken a pair of India's greatest middle-order batsmen a combined total of 245 Tests before their team has arrived in this place. As their careers run down,

these two varied but equally exquisite craftsmen will have their skills cotton-woolled when they should actually be out for public display. It's like the Medicis telling Michelangelo to stop chipping away at marble.

Except the BCCI, in charge of the team's calendar, seems less like the Medicis and more like the Borgia clan. Instead of playing matches that will establish India's dominance and put a distance between themselves and the

M.S. Dhoni's response was a little more cautious, "Well, I can't do anything about two Tests in six months... What we can do is whatever format we are asked to play, we play it. The schedule is almost done for a few years in advance... it is good to play Tests but at the same time we have to play whatever cricket is offered to us."

The formats that Dhoni is referring to are, of course, the ones which he has made his name: limited-overs. Both the 50-over ODIs and that most golden of all geese, Twenty20 which has lives of its own, as an international fixture and domestic product.

It is here that the BCCI has become house-proud, completely cornering the market with the super-dazzle and super-payouts of the Indian Premier League (IPL).

Naturally in the first half of 2010 then, India will play two Tests against Bangladesh and five ODIs against South Africa. For more than two months after that, they will be involved in six weeks of the IPL and two weeks of the ICC's World T20 event. In the year, a player like Dhoni will be playing as few as five Tests and competing in 23 T20 games and a minimum of 21 or maximum of 34 ODIs.

It is an extremely uneven balance that could deplete India's strength and energy in Tests which remain the toughest form of the game. This when the Test team goes on its most telling tour next December to South Africa, one of two major series it is still to win.

The year 2010 seems the worst planned in Indian cricket. BCCI President Shashank Manohar says that the current regime of the Board is not to blame. The current FTP agreement which has lop-sided schedules with India playing six Tests in 2009 and seven in 2010 was born in 2006. The opposing Jagmohan Dalmiya regime was already ousted from power and the BCCI was headed by Sharad Pawar as president and Niranjan Shah as secretary. Someone in that group sowed a very bad crop.

The BCCI's commitment to the long form of the game, Manohar maintains, is constant despite the tippy calendar and the IPL. "India was the only

“We are not to blame... we have to see whether it is advisable to play ICC events held every year.”



SHASHANK MANOHAR, PRESIDENT, BCCI

rest of the pack, India face crumbs.

While the pack will keep moving, keep hunting, India have been forced to stand still. All South Africa need to share the top spot with India is two Test wins against England in the four-Test series starting next week. Three victories and they will go ahead.

The No.1 ranking for India may last all of two weeks but that is not what the players are worried about. What irks them are the slim pickings in the new year. Two days after the Mumbai win over Sri Lanka, the most explosive Test opener in India's history told a newspaper that everyone was missing Tests. Virender Sehwag said, "We would all love to play more Tests... playing only four in a year is not at all enough. There should be at least eight to 10 in a year." Captain

THE GLORY BOYS: INDIA AFTER THE BRABOURNE WIN

TESTS IN 2010
According to ICC's Future Tours Programme

